

Chapter 5 Abstract

In 1915, Bardizag's Armenians community became the target of arrest, dispossession, deportation, enslavement and mass destruction. The fate of Bardizag raises a broader question: how did techniques of violence commonly associated with imperial frontiers come to be deployed against a popular living in the shadow of the imperial capital and transform labor relations in the region? The destruction of Bardizag, Adabazari, and neighboring Armenian communities formed part of a longer process through which techniques of colonial repression, demographic engineering, and irregular warfare migrated from the Ottoman Empire's frontiers back toward its political center. What scholars describe as the "colonial boomerang", the return of violence forged on imperial peripheries inward against populations closer to the metropole, found one of its clearest Ottoman expressions in the Marmara during the Armenian Genocide.

This paper approaches that question through the concept of the colonial boomerang. Associated most prominently with Aimé Césaire and Hannah Arendt, the colonial boomerang describes the return of coercive practices first developed against marginalized populations to the imperial center. The Ottoman case, however, suggest a modification of this framework. Rather than simply returning to the metropole, imperial violence operated through the creation of internal peripheries. The chapter further argues that the destruction of Bardizag was not solely a project of physical annihilation. Drawing on Nancy Fraser's distinction between exploitation and expropriation, it interprets the Armenian Genocide as a process of violent accumulation through which labor, property, and productive capacity were transferred from Armenians to the emerging structures of Turkish national economy. Through the conscription of Armenian men, the disappearance of communal leaders, the confiscation of property, forced deportation, and the coercive incorporation of survivors into new labor regimes. Bardizag reveals how genocide functioned simultaneously as destruction, dispossession, and economic reorganization.